

Weber 1930 RG Notes

Weber, Max. *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*. Trans. Talcott Parsons.
London: George Allen & Unwin, 1930 [1904–1905].

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- Some similarity between Marx and Weber, in that both were seeking to explain modern economic development and consider the conditions it both required and created – but, Weber took specific pieces of Marxist ideology while explicitly rejecting its total implementation/acquisition. Weber was particularly critical of some of the Marxist followers of this time and especially their revolutionary sentiments; instead sought a much more peaceful transition and to explain the organic development of the modern economy.
- Though desires for wealth acquisition are not novel, the contemporary West has become associated with “the rational organisation of formally free labour.” – its “routinised, calculated administration within continuously functioning enterprises.” This implies both a disciplined labour force and the regularised investment of capital. (Quote from interpreter but not from Weber)
- At this time, economic development and wealth accumulation seemed to be highly correlated with the presence of Protestant communities: such societies were achieving much greater economic development than their non-Protestant counterparts; in particular, Catholics.
- Weber claims that the underlying connection between Protestantism and a developed work ethic – particularly through the “virtuous” reinvestment of capital and pursuit of meaningful labor – were particularly key components in the development of modern economies (and in the heterogeneity of such development). Everyday men sought to pursue meaningful work, which in turn led to the development of massive amounts of capital and development

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- In a context of predestination post-Calvin, people sought to prove externally that they were to be saved, and performed worldly “good works” as a demonstration of surety. Subsequently, fulfilling one’s calling was no longer a means by which salvation could be achieved, but a signal to others that the individual was to be saved.

4 My Critiques

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